

Iceland's EU moment

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【メール原文】

POLITICO's must-read briefing on what's driving the day in Brussels, by Gerardo Fortuna, Nicholas Vinocur and Gabriel Gavin. By SEBASTIAN STARCEVIC GÓ

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GÓÐAN DAGINN. This is Sebastian Starcevic with a special Iceland-themed Playbook, just three weeks out from its referendum on EU membership talks.

In today's Playbook:

- How the EU could get two new members in 2028.
- Iceland's top diplomat says Reykjavík will go on the "attack" in EU negotiations.
- Faces in the crowd: Marta Kos, Þorgerður Katrín Gunnarsdóttir, Donald Trump, Ólafur Ragnar Grímsson, Ursula von der Leyen, Maida Gorčević and more.

On today's Brussels Playbook Week Ender: Sarah interviews Guy Verhofstadt, ex-MEP and Belgian PM, about his new book, "Defeating Trumpism." Plus, summer reading recommendations.

DRIVING THE DAY

PACKAGE DEAL: Iceland and Montenegro are lining up to join the EU at the same time in 2028 if Iceland votes to relaunch membership talks this month, with Brussels open to the idea of a package, eight diplomats and officials told Playbook.

Not a glacial pace: Enlargement Commissioner Marta Kos told Playbook that Iceland is a "special case" because of its membership in the EEA and Schengen Area, and predicted that talks could take just "one to two years" if Reykjavík decides to restart them on Aug. 29.

Neck and neck: That puts Iceland roughly on the same track as Montenegro, which has closed more than half of the 33 accession chapters it must work through to meet the criteria for EU membership and is racing to join the bloc by 2028. A senior Commission official involved in enlargement, granted anonymity to speak candidly, confirmed Iceland would quickly catch up to Podgorica.

Win-win: Given the timelines, a joint Montenegro-Iceland package, with member countries ratifying their bids together, is a strong possibility, another Commission official said. Iceland's wealth would

make it a net contributor to the EU budget and effectively pay for the membership of Montenegro, which would be among the poorest members of the bloc, they added.

There is precedent for bundling bids, such as Spain and Portugal joining the EU together in 1986 and Bulgaria and Romania in 2007, with member countries ratifying a single accession treaty in those cases. In 2004, 10 countries joined at the same time, also under one treaty.

Sharing the limelight: Montenegrin European Affairs Minister Maida Gorčević told Playbook on the sidelines of an embassy soirée that Podgorica would be happy to link its bid to Reykjavík's and join the EU together. And Icelandic Foreign Minister Þorgerður Katrín Gunnarsdóttir told us simultaneous accession was "absolutely" a prospect, depending on how negotiations go.

Joint membership is "the best-case scenario," a diplomat from one of the countries argued, while a second explained weaving the bids together could help win over France, which might get a far-right, anti-enlargement president in 2027. "A Montenegro-Iceland package would strengthen both our bids," the second diplomat said.

Hold your horses: All of this is contingent on what Icelanders decide when they vote this month. Recent polls show the country is almost evenly split on whether to relaunch talks, which were frozen by Reykjavík in 2013 in part over a dispute with Brussels about fishing rights. There would then need to be a second referendum once talks conclude.

Second time's the charm: Kos said the EU is ready to get "creative" to bring Iceland into the club and avoid another breakdown in negotiations. "Some of Iceland's specificities, particularly in fisheries and agriculture, are so unique that they must be taken into account," she said. But she added: "I am confident that ... we would find creative solutions that respect both sides."

BIG AND BREAKING

INFERNAL SUMMER: Aside from causing widespread human suffering, this summer's megafires will also take a heavy toll on Europe's fragile economy , Zia Weise explains.

SOTEU SOCIAL STRATEGY: Around 20 influencers from across Europe will be invited to Ursula von der Leyen's State of the European Union speech next month as part of the EU institutions' push to reach more people, two Commission officials told Playbook.

CHANCELLOR SWAP? There is increasingly open discussion of a Kanzlertausch to replace Friedrich Merz in the fall, Nette Nöstlinger reports from Berlin.

BLACKOUT DRILL: The French government is planning to organize a tabletop simulation of a sudden, nationwide power outage in the second half of 2027, our Paris bureau reports.

ICELAND PLAYS HARDBALL

PLAYING OFFENSE: Iceland will go on the "attack" to get the best possible deal with Brussels if voters back reopening EU membership talks later this month, Foreign Minister Þorgerður Katrín Gunnarsdóttir told Playbook.

Gunnarsdóttir, who belongs to a pro-EU party, said the country is in a much stronger position than in 2009 to negotiate a deal that protects its fisheries, agriculture and natural resources. "I'm a sport

person,” said the former professional handball player. “You can go into attack. We want to have and we need a strong agreement for Icelandic interests.”

O captain! My captain: If voters choose to relaunch talks, Reykjavík will appoint a chief negotiator to talk to Brussels. That person won’t be her. They will come from outside the foreign ministry, Gunnarsdóttir said, adding they will be someone who can “unite the nation” and be the “captain” of “team Iceland.”

Kitchen-table case: While much of Iceland’s referendum lead-up has been dominated by security concerns due to Donald Trump’s saber-rattling, the top diplomat pointed out that Iceland has “the most expensive grocery baskets in Europe,” with its interest rate more than triple the eurozone benchmark, and a “small, unstable, unpredictable” currency, the króna, which Gunnarsdóttir called an “unjust” burden on Icelanders.

Russia factor: Along with Trump and his Greenland threats, Iceland also has to worry about Moscow. “We see Russian ships here in [the] Icelandic economic zone, we know about how they monitor our infrastructure,” she said. “We need to think very carefully about where small nations stand and who stands with them.”

That’s BS: Gunnarsdóttir reserved her sharpest language for opponents of the referendum, accusing them of misleading voters by making “all kinds of bullshit” claims, including that Icelanders would be drafted into a European army.

Odds-on: Despite the fearmongering, she predicted the referendum on restarting talks will pass. “I believe we will get a yes. I believe in my people,” she said, adding Icelanders would not pass up “this huge opportunity we are facing now.”

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BIG BRUSSELS

TOO SMALL FOR BRUSSELS: Iceland’s government would get lost in the EU’s vast bureaucratic “jungle” if it joins the bloc, former President Ólafur Ragnar Grímsson told Playbook.

With around 400,000 people, Iceland would replace Malta (590,000) as the smallest EU member by population. Grímsson — who was president of Iceland for a record 20 years from 1996 to 2016 — said that would pose a manpower problem.

Small fish, big pond: With only “six or seven hundred officials” in core ministries, “far away from continental Europe and far away from Brussels,” it would be nearly impossible for Reykjavík to make its voice heard inside the bloc, the elder statesman said. “The vast number, tens of thousands of bureaucrats in Brussels ... a whole army of lobbyists ... it would be a bureaucratic jungle.”

Guðrún Hafsteinsdóttir, chair of Iceland’s largest opposition party, agreed that new talks would consume much of Iceland’s already lean civil service. “We don’t have so many working in the government here in Iceland,” she told Playbook. “If we say yes, then our whole system will be working on the accession process in the next two years.”

If it’s not broken ... While the EU’s draw for new members has usually been economic, Grímsson told Playbook that the island nation — which ranks at or near the top of global indexes for wealth, democracy and quality of life — is doing just fine on its own, pointing to its rich natural resources and

free trade agreements with China, the U.K. and others.

“We would have to surrender all these agreements,” he explained in an interview in the lobby of his hotel in Paris. “The EU is constructed in such a way that our absolute sovereign rule-making authority ... would partly be moved over to Brussels.”

Different path: The 83-year-old, who was born just before full Icelandic independence from Denmark, argued that sovereignty is an emotional issue for Icelanders. “We spent 100 years fighting a distant authority,” Grímsson said. “It is not a very appealing proposition that ... we should now spend the next 100 years dealing with a distant authority.”

BRUSSELS CORNER

WEATHER: Sunny intervals. High of 25C.

31 DAYS OF SOLITUDE: Paul Dallison’s latest Declassified humor column takes stock of the sad sight that is Brussels in August.

BREAD WINNERS: Where can you find Brussels’ best bagel? Your Playbook author has been on a mission the last couple of weeks to find out. The verdict: Léopold Café Royal makes a delicious hot goat’s cheese, apple, bacon and Liege syrup bagel. (Their chicken tandoori bagel, meanwhile, is acceptable.)

Six, seven ... Eight, a newly opened joint in the center, is getting rave reviews for its crispy sourdough bagels, which differ from the chewier New York-style fare. We recommend getting an everything bagel with a pot of cream cheese. In the European Quarter, Art’s and Bagels allows you to mix and match toppings yourself using a self-service touchscreen. And in Ixelles, you can’t go wrong with old favorite Holy Bagels.

TOP OF THE PLAYBOOKS

London: Conservative Leader Kemi Badenoch is opening a new front in the fight over immigration as her party tries to claw back support from Reform UK.

Paris: France’s presidential hopefuls are set for a flurry of activity over the next few weeks ahead of an autumn that could define the campaign.

Washington PM: Republican senators are keen to land a deal on government funding before the August recess, wary that a stalemate could hurt them in the midterms.

BIRTHDAYS

Former MEPs Nils Torvalds and Bart Staes; POLITICO’s Hans von der Burchard and Noah Keate; Salesforce’s Rachele Ciavarella; Matt Mazonkey from Airbus; Croatian politician Valter Drandić. European Commission’s Gianmarco Palermo.

Celebrating Saturday: Research Commissioner Ekaterina Zaharieva; MEP Thierry Mariani; Giuseppe Conte, former Italian PM and leader of Italy’s 5Star Movement; POLITICO’s Charlie Cooper; journalist Matthew Karnitschnig; Swiss tennis great Roger Federer; Ralph Gonsalves, former prime minister of

Saint Vincent and the Grenadines.

Celebrating Sunday: MEP Vytenis Andriukaitis, a former European commissioner; former MEP Helga Stevens; former European Commission President and ex-Italian PM Romano Prodi; former Secretary-General of the Council of the European Union Uwe Corsepius; Slovak perm rep's Pavol Kucharovic; Amazon Web Services' Katarzyna Koziol.

Playbook is brought to you by POLITICO's EU Politics team: Gerardo Fortuna, Nicholas Vinocur, Gabriel Gavin, Zoya Sheftalovich, Max Grier, Mari Eccles, Hanne Cokelaere and Sebastian Starcevic. And: reporters Ferdinand Knapp and Milena Wälde, editors Alex Spence and James Panichi, and producers Dean Southwell and Hugh Kapernaros.

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